



Everyday Green Practices in SMEs: Small Actions with Big Impact

🕒 15 min · Supporting learning resource (LSM)

Module 2 · From Awareness to Action-Skills for Sustainable Business

Unit 3 · Everyday Green Practices in the Workplace



Introduction

Sustainability is often associated with large investments, advanced technologies, or strategic business transformations. However, for most SMEs, the transition towards more sustainable practices begins with something much simpler: everyday actions.

Daily work routines—such as how energy is used, how materials are managed, or how decisions are made—have a direct impact on environmental performance. While each individual action may seem small, their cumulative effect over time can be significant.

This material explores how sustainability can be embedded into everyday work practices and how employees at all levels can contribute through simple, consistent actions.

Key concepts explained

Everyday sustainability in the workplace

Sustainability in SMEs is not limited to strategic decisions. It is closely connected to routine activities that take place every day.

For example, turning off equipment when it is not in use, reducing unnecessary printing, or organising workflows more efficiently are all examples of everyday sustainability practices.

These actions do not require specialised knowledge or significant resources. Instead, they rely on awareness and willingness to change small habits.

Over time, these practices can reduce energy consumption, minimise waste, and improve operational efficiency.

Low-cost, low-effort practices

One of the key advantages of everyday green practices is that they are accessible to all SMEs, regardless of size or resources.

Many effective actions are:

- low-cost
- easy to implement
- immediately applicable

For example:

- switching to digital documents instead of printing
- introducing simple end-of-day checks (lights, equipment)
- using resources more efficiently

These actions demonstrate that sustainability does not always require investment. It often begins with better use of existing resources.

Resource-saving behaviours

Everyday sustainability practices can be grouped into key areas:

Energy use

Employees can reduce energy consumption by switching off equipment, using energy-saving settings, and avoiding unnecessary use of devices.

Materials

Reducing paper use, reusing materials, and avoiding overconsumption can significantly decrease waste.

Water use

Simple awareness of water use can help avoid unnecessary consumption.

Mobility

Choosing more sustainable transport options or optimising logistics can reduce environmental impact.

These behaviours are simple but, when applied consistently, they lead to measurable improvements.

Behaviour and organisational habits

Many workplace practices are shaped by habits rather than conscious decisions.

For example, employees may print documents automatically, leave equipment running, or follow routines without questioning them.

Changing these habits is one of the most effective ways to improve sustainability. This does not require complex solutions, but rather:

- awareness
- small behavioural adjustments
- consistency over time

Organisations can support this process by encouraging reflection and promoting simple changes.

Reflection prompts

- Which everyday practices in your workplace affect resource use?
- Are there habits that could be improved?
- What is one small change you could apply immediately?
- How could your organisation support these changes?

Link to next unit

This unit focused on everyday practices and how small actions contribute to sustainability.

The next unit will explore how these practices can be further developed and integrated into broader organisational approaches to sustainability.

Why this matters for SMEs

For SMEs, everyday practices are particularly important because they are closely linked to daily operations.

Unlike large companies, SMEs often do not have dedicated sustainability departments. Therefore, improvements must come from within existing processes.

By adopting simple green practices, SMEs can:

- reduce operational costs
- improve efficiency
- strengthen their environmental performance
- engage employees in sustainability

This approach also allows SMEs to start small and gradually build more advanced sustainability strategies.

Practical examples or typical situations

Many SMEs can recognise situations such as:

- Equipment left running unnecessarily throughout the day
- Frequent printing of documents that could be shared digitally
- Inefficient use of materials leading to increased waste
- Lack of awareness about resource consumption

For example, a small office that switches from printed documents to digital workflows can significantly reduce paper use and costs.

Similarly, introducing a simple routine—such as checking equipment before leaving—can reduce energy consumption without any financial investment.

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